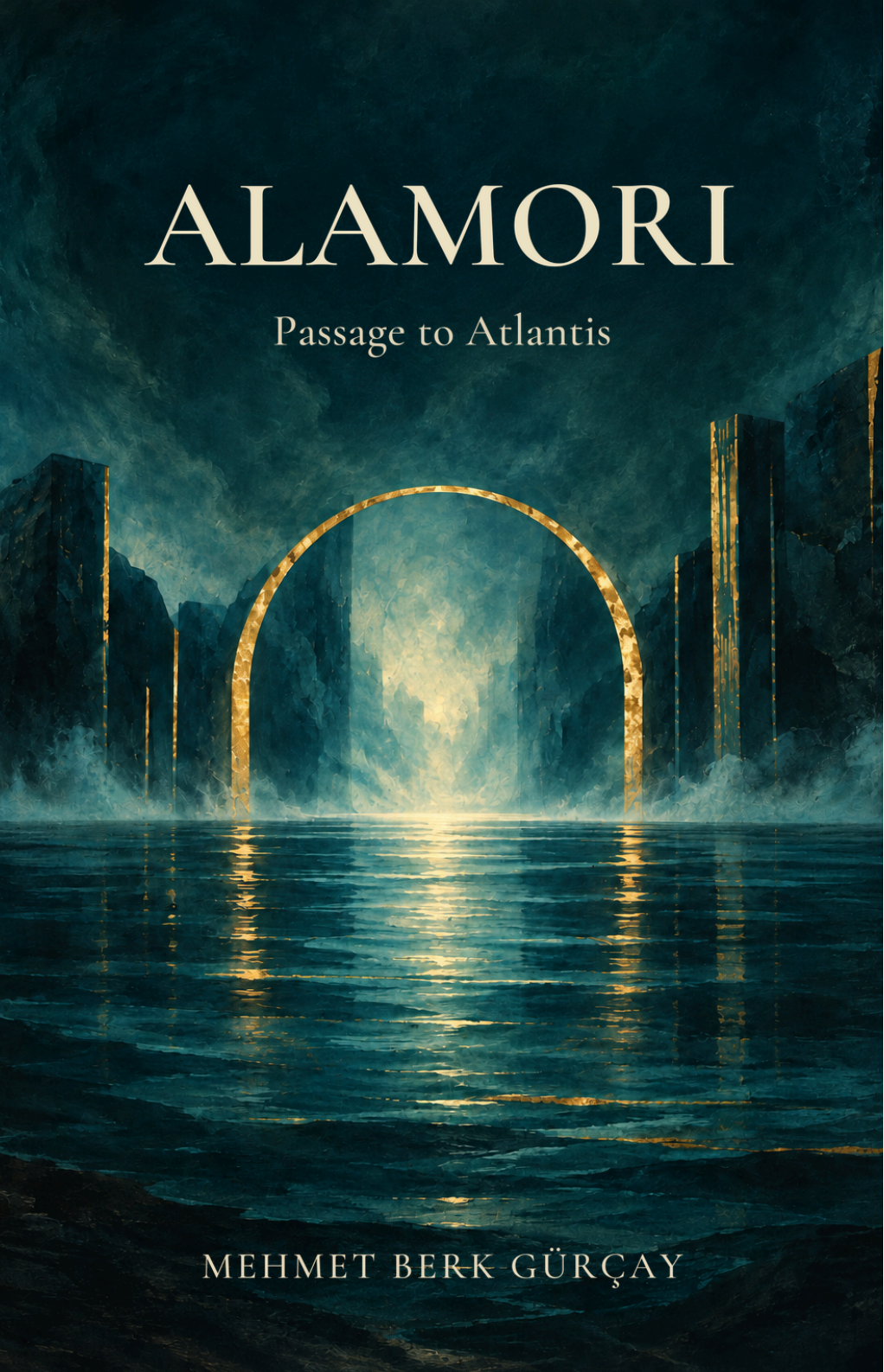
ALAMORI

Passage to Atlantis



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CHAPTER 1

Ostium



The day I began searching for Atlantis, all I wanted was to make my project stand out from the others in class.

A thin layer of snow covered the campus paths, crunching under my shoes. My breath drifted away in white mist.

I was working on a project about cities described in ancient texts, and I'd picked Atlantis. I wasn't expecting a great adventure. I only wanted to take a closer look at a legend everyone thought they knew, find solid sources, and hand the assignment in on time. To be honest, a good grade alone wouldn't have been enough. When the presentation was over, I wanted my classmates to think of my work whenever Atlantis came up.

St. Michel Library was one of the oldest buildings on campus. Among the university's newer buildings, its gray stone walls and narrow windows looked like something from another age. Most students used the modern library. People came here mostly for old sources, or for somewhere quiet to work.

Warm, heavy air hit my face as I came in. The sharp cold stayed outside. Wooden shelves reached the ceiling, and footsteps echoed through the high hall. After classes, emails, and the endless noise of campus, the silence felt good.

I knew Mike would be in the computer section at the front. I couldn't be bothered to go find him, so I took out my phone.

I wrote:

Are you at the library?

The reply came soon after:

Where did you expect me to be? In a cave?

I smiled and wrote again:

I need help with my Atlantis project.

This time there was no reply. I looked up. Mike was in the computer section, leaning so close to the screen his nose almost touched the monitor. He spun a pencil in his left hand while switching between two sources with his right.

I went over and leaned over his shoulder to look at the screen.

"What are you trying to solve this time?"

Without looking away, Mike said, "Somebody wrote a date down wrong."

"How do you know?"

"Two sources give different years for the same event. One is wrong. I can't move on until I know which."

The pencil stopped for a moment. Mike frowned, then started spinning it again.

"Something doesn't fit," he muttered. "My brain is itching."

"That might be a disease."

"Maybe. Let me fix the date first."

At last he turned to me. His eyes were tired behind his glasses, but alert.

"So, Atlantis," he said. "The topic half the class will copy from the internet in two minutes."

"I want to do it better."

"That's usually how our trouble starts."

"Will you help?"

Mike looked at the screen, then at me. The pencil stopped.

"Sure. But first we need to know what you're looking for. Its history, its legends, or whether it really existed?"

“For now, a general source. The city, its people, its language… things like that.”

He started spinning the pencil faster.

“A city with a language is more interesting than a legend.”

“Where did you get that?”

“I didn’t. You said it.”

We talked about the project for a while. Mike suggested databases, gave me some source names, and told me to check old maps.

He looked at his watch.

“I’m getting coffee.”

“Now?”

“Two minutes. If I don’t, that date will keep eating at me.”

“Because of one date?”

“Not because it’s a date. Because it’s still unanswered.”

He left his pencil beside the computer and stood. His coat stayed on the chair.

“Harvey, start with normal sources. Don’t get lost among the old shelves.”

“I never get lost.”

“You spent three hours in the basement last year.”

“All the corridors looked the same.”

Mike shook his head and left. I opened my notes and headed toward the back shelves.

The first half hour was ordinary. I found several books about Atlantis and took notes. They all described a grand city beneath the sea, a powerful civilization, and an unexplained destruction.

I had three book titles in my notebook, but the notes beneath them were almost identical. A presentation built on them wouldn’t be any different from everyone else’s.

I moved farther back to look for older sources. The shelves were sparser and the aisles narrower. The students' voices faded. There were a few empty tables and a closed reading room, but no one around.

Where the shelves ended, there was a narrow door. Next to it hung a small sign.

ANCIENT ARCHIVE — ACCESS BY SPECIAL PERMISSION ONLY

Under the sign was an old card, yellowed at the edges. The two lines I could make out read **maritime civilizations** and **post-Platonic records**.

If I asked a librarian, they'd probably send me back to the same books. I looked at the card again. The door hadn't quite latched. It wasn't locked.

I'd only look at the titles on the shelves. If there was nothing about Atlantis, I'd close the door and leave.

I turned the handle. The door opened with a dry click, and cold air slipped out. In the dim room, shelves rose to the ceiling and long covered tables stood between them.

I pushed the door farther open.

Footsteps came from the corridor behind me. Two people were speaking quietly. I couldn't make out the words, but they were coming closer.

My hand was still on the handle. I had opened the door; if someone saw me, I couldn't pretend it was an accident. If I went inside, maybe they'd pass.

I stepped in and slowly closed the door.

The room was colder than the main hall. Thin frost lined the windows. Three tall rows of shelves stood opposite the door, with narrow aisles between them. The covers on the two

long tables almost touched the floor. Dust drifted in the pale light.

I checked the shelves. Most books were in Latin, Greek, or languages I didn't know. Some bindings were cracked; some titles had almost faded away.

Then one book caught my eye.

It stood at the end of the shelf among the others. At first it looked ordinary. The leather was worn, the corners frayed. But a faint emblem on the cover seemed to change shape with the light.

I took it from the shelf.

It was lighter than I expected. My hands tensed when I realized I was holding it without permission. Maybe it was the excitement of finding what I'd been looking for. Or the thought that no one else had found it.

I opened it.

The first pages showed circular structures, towers by the sea, and lines connecting them. I couldn't read the main text. Notes in different hands filled the margins. Most were symbols I didn't understand, but some used letters I could read.

One word appeared again and again:

Alamori.

I wrote it in my notebook. It could be a place, a person, or something else. All I knew was that it appeared more than the other words written in letters I could read.

I could have put the book back. I should have. But I wanted to see more. I kept turning the pages.

I copied a few more words.

As I closed my notebook, the door handle turned.

I froze.

The door opened slowly. Someone entered and stopped among the shelves. From where I was, I could only see their shoes beneath the shelf.

I held my breath. I had no idea what I'd say if they saw me. I'd been caught alone in the archive.

The book closed under my hands. I don't remember pushing it into my bag. As I got to my feet, all I could think about was getting out without being seen.

The person moved to another shelf. A book scraped free. The shoes disappeared.

The door hadn't closed fully. A covered table stood between me and it, only a few steps away.

I left my bag unzipped; the zipper might make noise. I slipped the strap over my shoulder and moved sideways without touching the table. Behind the shelf, a page turned.

At the door, the shelf was still between us. I didn't look back.

Holding the bag to my chest, I slipped out and didn't turn around until the corner. I never saw the person's face. It didn't occur to me then that they might have been the one who left the archive unlocked.

I stopped around the corner. The bag was still open. I could leave the book outside the archive, or put it back once the person inside left.

My hand touched the cover, but I didn't take it out. If I returned it, I might never see it again. After finding a book about Atlantis among all those shelves, I didn't want to walk away empty-handed. It felt like giving up a chance I might never get again.

I knew none of that justified taking it. The first move had been panic. The second hadn't.

I left the corridor and returned to the main hall. Mike was back at the computers with a fresh coffee. He looked up.

"Harvey, what did you find?"

I tightened the strap on my shoulder.

"A few sources."

"A few sources?"

His eyes went from my face to the open bag. It didn't take him long to spot the cover.

Mike looked surprised, then frowned.

"That's from the Ancient Archive."

"Yes."

"You can't take that out."

"I know."

"Harvey."

"It's about Atlantis. It might be exactly what I need."

Mike glanced toward the entrance.

"We're not talking here."

He grabbed his coat and pulled me into an empty study room. Even after closing the door, his fingers kept moving.

"First," he said, "did you think about how you'd get the book out?"

"Someone came in."

"So no. You can't just put it in your bag and walk out. Books you haven't checked out set off the alarm. And no one's letting you take this one out."

I put my bag on the table. "Fine. We'll think now."

"You should have thought before putting it in your bag."

"Let's list our options instead of panicking."

"I can do both."

Mike turned his chair toward the door, pulled my notebook over, and wrote **put it back** at the top.

“Safest option,” he said. “Hand it in and admit you went in without permission.”

“And never get near it again.”

“Probably. You could get a disciplinary hearing too.”

“Then it’s out.”

Mike tapped his pencil. “It’s not out. You just don’t like it.”

We also considered hiding it inside and waiting until closing. Both ideas were crossed out. Staff would check the rooms, the doors would be locked, and the service exit needed an employee card.

Mike checked the back cover. “There’ll be an RFID tag in the binding. We can’t pass the exit without disabling it.”

I suggested aluminum foil.

“Don’t believe everything online,” he said. “We’re not baking a potato.”

“We won’t know unless we try.”

“I don’t want to find out at the door.”

Mike put his phone on the table. “We could photograph the pages you need and return it.”

I looked at the book. Hundreds of pages. We couldn’t read the main text, didn’t know which notes mattered, and some drawings covered two pages.

“How do we choose?”

“City drawings. Alamori. A few notes.”

“And then try to sneak back in because we skipped one mark.”

“Photographing everything would take forever,” Mike said. “Still better than stealing it.”

A few photos weren’t enough. I didn’t know what I was looking for, so I didn’t want to leave anything out.

“We need the whole thing.”

Mike watched me. “Then you’re not looking for a source. You want every possibility with you.”

I said nothing.

Mike drew a line under the list.

“Then we need two things,” I said. “A distraction and a way past the alarm.”

“We can still put it back.”

He reached for the book but turned the cover toward himself instead. His thumb traced the faded emblem.

“This isn’t printed,” he murmured.

“Mike.”

He looked back at the list. Then his eyes moved through the glass toward the red alarm button in the corridor.

“We don’t need to be quiet,” he said.

“What?”

“No. Forget it. I didn’t say that.”

I followed his gaze. “The fire alarm.”

“Yes. While security deals with the fire, the exit alarm might be ignored.” His voice dropped. “That doesn’t make it a good idea.”

“If we only press the button, there’s no smoke. No one will take it seriously.”

Mike grimaced. “We’re not starting a fire.”

“A tiny one.”

“Sure. We’ll tell it to stay tiny.”

In the photocopy area, away from the shelves, stood a metal bin.

“You don’t have to do it,” I said.

Mike looked up. “What will you do?”

“I’ll find a way.”

“We could get caught. Suspended. If the fire spreads, we could damage more than one book.”

“I know.”

Mike closed the book, then opened it again. He looked at the figures beside Alamori, found another page with the same word, picked up his pencil, then put it down.

Finally, he crossed out **put it back**.

“Only a few sheets,” he said. “I’ll light them. Once there’s smoke, I’ll trigger the alarm. You carry the book, but don’t go to the exit without me.”

“Okay.”

“If it gets big, we drop the book and put it out.”

“Okay.”

Mike took a lighter out of the front pocket of his bag. He caught me looking.

“I use it for cables at the club. I don’t smoke.”

He stood. His hands were shaking.

We went to the metal bin. Mike checked where the fire extinguisher was, crouched, and lit a sheet of paper. Thin smoke rose. The paper curled, and the flame suddenly grew.

Mike jumped back.

“That’s enough!”

He lifted the cover over the alarm and looked at me.

I nodded. He pressed the button.

The alarm rang through the shelves. Students looked up. A staff member pointed toward the exit; chairs moved, bags were grabbed, and people from two corridors merged into one passage. The smell of burning paper spread into the hall.

Mike stayed by the alarm. The flame still burned behind him, the crowd thickening ahead.

“Mike!”

He came over and pulled me to the edge of the crowd.

Behind us, a staff member grabbed the extinguisher and ran toward the smoke. As the smell spread, people moved faster.

At the main corridor, two lines collided. I kept my bag between myself and the wall. A backpack hit my arm while someone behind told us to move. Mike didn't let go.

At the exit, staff directed everyone outside. As we crossed the threshold, the security alarm beeped and a light turned red. Mike pushed me forward. No one stopped us.

Outside, the alarm faded behind the walls.

Cold air hit my face. Neither of us spoke. Snow kept falling over the campus as quietly as before.

Mike bent over, hands on his knees.

"We're never doing that again."

"It worked."

Mike didn't answer.

Students stood outside without their coats. Staff counted them while security kept everyone out. Soon we heard fire-engine sirens.

Mike straightened.

"We did all this."

A student beside us hugged himself against the cold. His hands were red. I looked away. Mike pushed the lighter deep into his pocket.

Security tape went up. A staff member announced that the small fire was out, but St. Michel's old wing would stay closed until the smoke cleared and safety checks were complete. The corridor to the Ancient Archive would also remain closed.

I felt the book's weight on my shoulder. We'd gotten it out, but we'd also closed the way back.

Away from the library, we bought two coffees and sat on a bench. Mike held his cup with both hands; his fingers were still shaking.

I thought about apologizing. I asked something else instead.

"Are you angry with me?"

"Yes."

"The alarm was your idea."

"That doesn't mean I can't be angry."

He took a sip, then looked at my bag.

"Why do you want this book so badly?"

"For my project."

Mike raised an eyebrow.

"That answer came too fast."

I stayed quiet. Saying I thought the book was special would sound ridiculous.

"No other Atlantis source is like this," I said. "I want to understand it."

Mike looked down.

"So do I," he said. "That's the problem."

There was nothing funny about it, but I laughed. Mike stared at me, then laughed too. When we stopped, red lights were still flashing over the snow.

Mike put down his cup. "I'm coming home with you tonight. You're not opening that book alone."

After everything that had happened, I couldn't argue.

* * *

That evening, Mike came home with me. When I set the book on my desk, my room still felt familiar and safe. My half-finished notes lay by the window, clothes were strewn across the bed, the calendar hung on the wall. The book looked out of place among it all.

Mike hung his coat on the chair, took out his notebook, and sat opposite me.

"This time, I take the notes," he said. "We talk before trying anything."

"Okay."

"First, what do we know?"

"It's about Atlantis."

"We think it is. Not the same thing."

We opened the book and studied the pages more carefully. I noticed symbols I'd missed in the library. Mike moved between pages, looking for repeated marks and copying them. He couldn't identify the language. He thought the margin notes had been added later. Some copied the main symbols; others used letters we could read, numbers, and arrows.

Mike photographed the two pages with the clearest notes.

Alamori appeared elsewhere too, usually beside the same human figures.

"Not a place," Mike said, comparing two drawings. "It's always beside these people. It must be the name of their people."

He wrote:

Alamori — name of a people

On each page, Mike studied the text layout, then the drawings. I kept following where the same word appeared.

We treated one mark as a number, but the pattern failed on the third drawing. Mike crossed it out and started again. We compared the margin notes with the main text; the same symbol seemed to work differently each time.

At one point, Mike brought two coffees from the kitchen. By the time he finished his, I had gone through the same five pages again and again, marking every Alamori.

The desk filled with notes and page numbers. We were no closer to understanding the book.

Mike checked his phone.

"It's past midnight."

"One more page."

"You've been saying that for ten pages." He took his coat. "I have a lab in the morning. If I'm late, they won't let me into the experiment."

I walked him to the door.

Mike put his notebook away.

"Close the book."

"In a minute."

He waited, then left. The room went quiet.

I returned to the desk. I'd just take one more look at the page I'd left half done. On a blank sheet, I wrote three possible meanings for one word and added a question mark to each. The fourth time I copied the same symbol, my pencil tip broke.

I put the pencil down and closed the book. A few seconds later, I opened it again.

When I could read no more, I closed it and went to bed.

I dreamed of Atlantis.

Stone towers rose above the sea, streets disappeared into mist, and a dark square lay before me. I couldn't tell how large the city was. Everything seemed far away and close at once.

Water ran through narrow stone channels around the square. But instead of flowing down, it climbed the walls toward the tower tops. Even in the dream, I knew it was wrong, but I couldn't look away.

A silver-haired woman stood in the square. I couldn't see her face clearly. She tried to speak, but the wind broke apart her voice.

At last I made out what she was saying.

"Help me."

I woke with the blanket on the floor and my hand gripping the edge of the bed.

I looked at the book. For a moment, I thought the emblem glowed faintly. Then the light shifted and it went dull again.

The fear stayed. For the first time, I wondered how bad an idea it had been to keep the book at home. Should I return it?

I put it in my bag. I'd talk to Mike in the morning.

* * *

I went to campus early. Standing by the old classroom building, I texted Mike:

Come now. Something happened with the book.

He arrived soon after without even saying hello.

"Did we get caught?"

"No."

"Where's the book?"